

MEDICAL OFFICE PRACTICUM



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Medical Office Practicum

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Western
Technical College

InfoPage

I developed this OER textbook as part of a newly created course at Western Technical College within the Medical Administrative Professional program. Its primary purpose is to serve as a free, accessible resource that reinforces the knowledge students have gained throughout their first year in the program. This OER functions as a practical review tool, consolidating key concepts from prior coursework to help students confidently transition into the workforce.

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Detailed Licensing

Licensing

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1.1: Preparing for Employment

Preparing for an Employment Search

As you begin your search for employment, first you need to evaluate your skills, both personal and professional, as well as your overall goal. Make a list of personal traits and professional skills that you are confident with. After compiling this list, the next step is the job searching!

Many resources are available to job seekers through easily accessible venues.

- Classified Ads
- Professional Publications
- Career/Job Fairs
- Temporary Employment Agencies
- Employment Services
- Networking (face-to-face)
- Chamber of Commerce
- Direct contact with companies

Applications

Whether you complete an application electronically or traditionally, you should prepare to share some personal information. You may also be requested to submit a cover letter and/or resume; these topics will be discussed in the upcoming sections.

For an application, ensure the following information is easily accessible for successful completion.

1. **Personal Information:** In addition to name and address, you may be asked to document your Social Security number.
2. **Name of Position Desired:** State the name of the position or positions in which you are application applies.
3. **Work History:** Your work history with employers name, address, direct supervisors' name and contact information and duration of employment will be asked.
4. **Criminal History:** Honesty is the best policy. State the facts- what happened and how you have changed from the experience. All healthcare organizations will require a background check, so being honest from the start is best!
5. **Military History:** Be prepared to record dates and ranks.
6. **Education:** Have available any postsecondary education information (even if you haven't graduated yet). Applications usually ask for the names and addresses of schools, dates attended, degrees earned or in progress, hours completed and your grade point average (GPA).
7. **References:** You will almost always be asked to share 3 references for the employer to contact to get more information on who you are as a person. Immediate relatives (parents, siblings, cousins, aunts and uncles) should not be listed as references! Also, entering 'References Available Upon Request', is not best practice and could lose you the opportunity to interview!

Always remember to check your spelling, grammar; double check that all fields are completed correctly!

Source

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1.2: Purpose of a Resume

Purpose of a Resume

Resumes are no longer a literal account of your work history; they are a strategic story of your most marketable skills and experiences. Think of your resume as a marketing tool and imagine yourself as the product that you are marketing. This is your opportunity to sell yourself and your skills in order to create a strong, memorable, and confident first impression.

Remember also that your resume is a living, breathing document and should be continually updated as you change, learn, and grow. Since it is often your very first introduction to a prospective employer, **your document needs to impress the hiring manager enough for them to want to meet with you in person and invite you for an interview.** When employers receive large quantities of resumes, they simply don't have the time and resources to retain all the information you are presenting. That is why it is essential to be as clear as possible; this will allow the employer or hiring committee to find the information they are looking for within the few seconds they take to read it over.

An effective resume will:

- Include keywords from the job posting.
- Demonstrate your ability to organize and present ideas clearly and professionally.
- Show your attention to detail by being free of errors.
- Provide details of your relevant experience and education credentials.

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1.2.1: Resume Types

Resume Types

First and foremost, there is no single “right” way to do your resume. Every resume should be strategically designed to represent your individual circumstances and best highlight your “fit” for the position you are applying for. Some resume styles are more appropriate for specific occupations or fields than others and some industries may be more accepting of a shorter or longer resume depending on their needs, time, and resources. If you are unsure which format to use, read the explanations below and consider going straight to the source by having people in the field you are targeting, or the companies you are interested in working for, offer you feedback and input.

- **Chronological:** This common format focuses on work experience and education and places less emphasis on the skills section of the resume. Experience is featured on the first page of the resume, listing it in reverse chronological order (most recent first). This format is best used by job seekers who have significant work experience and education related to the job. It lets the reader see career stability, career progression, and includes details about each job held.
- **Functional:** This format is sometimes recommended to those with minimal experience, career-changers who are transitioning from one area of expertise to another, and individuals with gaps in their work history. This format focuses more on skills and less on experience. Keep in mind that this format may make it difficult for employers to see where your experience has been gained.
- **Combination:** This format combines the skills and experience section from a functional format with the details of a work experience section found in a chronological format. The combination format allows students and new graduates to highlight skills gained through their education as well as emphasize their practical experience obtained from field placements, co-op, applied research, and team projects.

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1.2.2: Resume Sections

Resume Sections

Contact Information

- This section typically includes your name, home address, and contact information (phone, email) and links to your LinkedIn profile, online portfolios, or websites (if applicable).
- Including an address is optional, however, it is suggested to include your address when you're applying for local positions and it is suggested to remove your address if you are looking for jobs in different cities or countries.
- Your phone number should lead to a voicemail message and your voicemail message should indicate to an employer what number they have reached.
- Your email address should reflect your professional image, which is usually some combination of your first and last name or initials, avoid using a humorous or inappropriate email address.

Profile or Objective Statement

- This section is a brief 2-3 sentence summary of your qualifications and experience as they relate to your overall job goal or job posting for which you are applying to.
- The profile can be written in point form or a short paragraph or it can be a combination of both. Highlighting the number of years' experience or the program you are studying will give you a robust introduction.
- This section can also emphasize personal skills requested in the job posting (e.g. adaptable, innovative, quick learner, positive etc.).
- Many of you may be more familiar with the Objective Statement. Although this may have been appropriate when seeking interim employment, employers seem to prefer the Profile to the Objective at a career-level search as it focuses more on what a candidate can contribute, rather than just stating what they want.

Summary of Qualifications

This section:

- Highlights related professional skills and experiences that you have gained through studies, work, and volunteer activities.
- Includes relevant soft skills, for example, interpersonal, communication, organizational, problem-solving, leadership, and teamwork skills and how or where you demonstrated them.
- Includes required or asset certifications, for example, First Aid, WHMIS, Health and Safety, etc.
- Uses information from learning outcomes and course outlines to reflect professional skills gained during studies.
- Positions and prioritizes points to match the posting (order of importance from employer's viewpoint).
- Uses keywords from the job posting and the occupation specific language/terminology.
- Lists computer skills and other technical skills relevant to your field.
- Does not include skills/knowledge that cannot be supported by examples.

Education

- In this section, include a list of your education, in **reverse chronological order** (most recent information first), including Diplomas/Degrees/Certificates, the year in which you obtained them, or the dates in which you are currently completing them, the school you attended, and the locations.
- List relevant courses, using the correct course titles, especially courses that relate closely to the requirements of the job.
- Include your secondary school information if it is your only other educational experience.
- Information on relevant courses or notable GPAs can be included as a bullet point underneath. Ensure that you indicate what your GPA is out of, for example, 3.5/4.0, as different schools have varying scales.

Work Experience

- In this section, list your work experience in **reverse chronological order** (most recent information first), stating the job title, company name, and dates clearly and visibly.

- Under each entry, your job descriptions should be written effectively as bullets, using scope and accomplishment statements to highlight your relevant transferable skills.

Additional Experience Section Considerations

- If you have relevant academic and applied projects, work or clinical placements, co-op, part-time, and summer, and volunteer jobs, you can consider separating your work experience into “Related Experience” and “Other Experience.” The “Related Experience” would be presented first and would make a stronger connection to your current job goal. If you don’t necessarily have the experience that relates, you can simply place all of your experience under “Work Experience.”

Other Possible Resume Sections Include:

- Volunteer Experience
- Certifications
- Professional Development or Training
- Awards
- Memberships
- Activities

What Not to Include on a Resume

- Personal information, such as age, date of birth, marital status, ethnicity, religion.
- Photographs or graphics, with the exception of art, media or design related occupations.
- Information that is out-of-date (typically more than 10 years old) or that is not relevant to the position.
- Certifications that are expired or not relevant to the job that you are applying to.
- Your references.

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- Dilgert, E., & Weatherhead, N. (2021). *Career guide for health and wellness office administrative professionals*. Conestoga College.

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1.2.3: Keywords

Use Keywords

For your resume to be effective in clearly demonstrating that you have the knowledge, skills, and abilities to perform the essential duties of the role, it must be targeted to each job by including keywords from the job posting.

Keywords are terms that describe the type of person and skillset/education/experience that the employer requires.

Omitting keywords from your resume and cover letter may result in your documents getting discarded before anyone reads them!

Examples of soft skills keywords: work ethic, dependability, willingness to learn, teamwork, self-motivated, ability to work with little or no supervision, critical thinking, creativity/innovation, verbal and written communication, organization, flexibility, time management, calm and compassionate, accurate, attention to detail, multitasking, positive, cheerful, outgoing, friendly, helpful, professional, courteous

Examples of hard skills keywords: typing, speaking another language, MS Office, clinical information software/EMR, transcription, billing (OHIP/private), payroll, financial reports, accounting, medical terminology

Examples of knowledge keywords: Health Office Administration diploma, medical terminology course, or equivalent experience preferred

1. **Look up job postings** you are interested in applying for and examine the qualifications/duties listed. Next, make a match between your skills, knowledge, and experience and the job requirements. Looking at job postings that reflect your job goal will provide you with a sense of the common requirements that an employer might be looking for and assist you in tailoring your resume to those jobs in the future.
2. **Use labor market information** resources such as the [Bureau of Labor Statistics](#) website to review various career and occupational profiles and understand the required duties and responsibilities. This can be used as a guide to inform you of all the various tasks and duties that are associated with different jobs.
3. **Refer to your program learning outcomes** – For each program at Western Technical College, program and learning outcomes are identified in order for you as a student to understand what abilities you will reliably be able to demonstrate upon graduation. The learning outcomes were developed by employers and industry professionals prior to the creation of your course and offer industry-specific language that you can apply to your resume.

? Prepare

1. Find a job posting that interests you and identify all the keywords.
2. List the keywords from the posting that match your own skills and use these in your resume and cover letter for that job.

Use Action Verbs

We know that employers and hiring managers are bombarded with applications; therefore, you are not doing yourself any favors by using all the same, old, tired words that everyone else is using. Starting each sentence with a strong action verb will capture the attention of the employer and provide a clearer, more interesting picture of what you have done.

Review your resume, go back and look at each word and ask yourself, is it powerful, appropriate, and exciting? **Avoid using the same word more than once.**

COMMUNICATION

- Arranged
- Authored
- Collaborated
- Communicated
- Consulted
- Corresponded
- Debated
- Defined
- Discussed

- Drafted
- Edited
- Explained
- Interacted
- Interpreted
- Interviewed
- Joined
- Listened
- Marketed
- Mediated
- Moderated
- Negotiated
- Observed
- Participated
- Persuaded
- Presented
- Publicized
- Reported
- Responded
- Translated
- Wrote

MANAGEMENT

- Administered
- Analyzed
- Appointed
- Approved
- Assigned
- Attained
- Authorized
- Chaired
- Coordinated
- Designed
- Delegated
- Directed
- Established
- Executed
- Led
- Managed
- Motivated
- Organized
- Oversaw
- Planned
- Prioritized
- Reviewed
- Scheduled
- Supervised

TEACHING/HELPING

- Advised
- Aided
- Answered
- Assisted
- Clarified
- Coached
- Contributed
- Demonstrated
- Educated
- Encouraged
- Evaluated
- Explained
- Facilitated
- Guided
- Helped
- Individualized
- Informed
- Instilled
- Instructed
- Motivated
- Persuaded
- Resolved
- Simplified
- Supported
- Taught
- Trained
- Tutored
- Volunteered

FINANCIAL

- Administered
- Adjusted
- Allocated
- Appraised
- Audited
- Balanced
- Budgeted
- Calculated
- Estimated
- Forecasted
- Netted
- Projected
- Purchased
- Qualified
- Reconciled
- Reduced

CLERICAL

- Arranged
- Cataloged
- Classified
- Collected
- Compiled
- Filed
- Organized
- Prepared
- Processed
- Recorded
- Scheduled

RESEARCH

- Analyzed
- Collected
- Compiled
- Filed
- Organized
- Prepared
- Processed
- Recorded
- Scheduled

CREATIVE

- Arranged
- Acted
- Composed
- Created
- Customized
- Designed
- Developed
- Directed
- Established
- Fashioned
- Founded
- Illustrated
- Invented
- Modeled
- Originated
- Performed
- Shaped
- Solved

TECHNICAL

- Adapted
- Applied
- Assembled
- Built
- Computed
- Debugged

- Designed
- Developed
- Engineered
- Installed
- Maintained
- Operated
- Programmed
- Remodeled
- Solved
- Standardized
- Tested
- Upgraded

Scope Statements

When developing your resume, you can really set yourself apart from others by writing strong summaries of your duties at past and current employment or volunteer positions. Use scope statements to describe what you did at each job or volunteer position. **You may feel that your experience is limited or unrelated and that it's not worth describing your tasks in detail; however, oftentimes we are actually gaining and using transferable skills without even realizing it.**

Focus on including the following components in your descriptions:

1. Task: Identify the day-to-day activities you were expected to complete.
2. Skill: Decide which transferable skills you used to perform the tasks.
3. Outcome: State the outcome of the task.

Even in your part-time and volunteer jobs, you've gained many applicable transferable skills, take a look:

- Interacted with customers (Task) by listening carefully (Skill) to answer questions about store products (Outcome).
- Sold store merchandise (Task) by upselling product benefits (Skill) to meet daily sales goals (Outcome).
- Handled cash (Task) accurately in a busy environment (Skill) to ensure store till was balanced before closing (Outcome).

Accomplishment Statements

Accomplishment statements are highly favored by employers because they provide tangible evidence as to what you can bring to the workplace and substantiate the skills or competencies you present on your resume. **Accomplishment statements also demonstrate why you would be the best candidate for the position** and can be used by employers to help differentiate you when compared to other applicants who may have had similar experiences.

Start by brainstorming the tasks and activities you performed well in your past or current experience. Typically, these are characterized by occasions where you recognized a problem or a situation that could have been improved, you acted or responded to it, and it resulted in recognition or a positive outcome. When thinking about each experience, ask yourself the following question: How was my performance measured in this position and what value did I bring to this workplace or organization?

It can be helpful to list your experiences to date (work, volunteer, education, academic projects, assignments, and presentations) and identify achievements for each of these. Think of significant contributions, individual or group projects, recognition received from a formal performance review, or informally from coworkers, team members, customers, professors, and supervisors. Accomplishments can also include awards or any contributions you made that had a positive impact on your workplace.

Reflection Questions

What are your accomplishments? Ask yourself these questions:

- Have you received praise from managers, supervisors, instructors, or clients?
- Have you ever been assigned a task that you could do better than others?
- Have you ever been asked to train anyone?

How did you distinguish yourself or set yourself apart in your last job? What did you do to show your initiative?

- When did you go above and beyond your job duties to complete a task and/or satisfy a customer?
- Have you ever been promoted, recognized, awarded, or thanked by your coworkers?
- How did your work affect the strategic business operations?

Source

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1.2.4: Tips and Samples

Resume Tips

Customize your resume to match the job requirements.

- Clearly indicate and provide details of relevant experience, qualifications, and education credentials.
- The employer needs to be able to find the essential information in a short period of time, as often in the first step of the selection process resumes are read or scanned in only 30-60 seconds.
- Use keywords from the job posting and the occupation-specific language/terminology.

Create a strong first impression.

- Keep the format simple and professional.
- Use 11- or 12-point font size and web-friendly fonts.
- Avoid using graphics, multiple styles of bullets and fonts, tables, and columns.
- Use sub headings and a space between sections to ensure that your resume is clear and easy to read.
- Ensure that your formatting is consistent throughout. For example, bullets and dates should be aligned in all sections, and dates should be presented consistently as full month or abbreviated month.
- Showcase your skills on a two-page resume: this is the expectation once you are a post-secondary student, graduate, or experienced worker, but can vary depending on individual circumstance and industry preferences.

Keep it error free!

- Demonstrate your attention to detail by being free of grammar and spelling errors.
- Do not use *I, my, myself, me*
- Proofread your resume; do not rely solely on spellcheck.
- Have a second person proofread your resume; a second set of eyes may see what you have missed.

Emphasize your education.

- Review program and course learning outcomes; describe practical projects, labs, assignments, work placements, and co-op experiences that you have completed during your studies. Include your GPA if it is notable: e.g. above 3.0 / 4.0.

Include transferrable or “soft skills.”

- Describe your interpersonal, communication, organizational, problem solving, leadership, and teamwork skills and/or other soft skills that you gained from part-time jobs, volunteer, or extra-curricular activities.
- Make an effort to identify the soft skills that are mentioned in the job posting you are applying to.

Be action-oriented and highlight accomplishments.

- Add value, provide tangible evidence, and increase credibility by including numbers, statistics, percentages, or figures and by using strong accomplishment statements and action verbs when describing your experiences.
- Accomplishments can include awards and formal recognitions, but also any contributions you made that had a positive impact on your workplace.

Focus on compatibility.

- Submit your application in the file format that is suggested on the posting, however, if not otherwise specified, submit in Microsoft Word or as a PDF.
- Avoid using unique fonts and bullets that may not be compatible across different word processing software.
- Be cautious when using resume templates, tables, or columns, as Applicant Tracking Systems may not be able to read them properly.

Add relevant links.

- Be sure to include website addresses to your online portfolio, a completed professional LinkedIn profile, or other relevant links that demonstrate your work, if applicable.

Resume Samples

The list below has resume samples for various areas of study. Click on the resumes to view them.

- [Business Administration](#) [opens a PDF].
- [Child and Youth Care](#) [opens a PDF].
- [Event Planning](#) [opens a PDF].
- [Nursing](#) [opens a PDF].
- [Office Administration Executive](#) [opens a PDF].

Source

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1.3: Purpose of Cover Letters

Cover Letters are Important

Why should you create a targeted cover letter to accompany your resume?

- Preparing a well-thought-out, personalized, customized, and compelling cover letter is an effective job search strategy that can give you an **advantage over other applicants** and increase your chances of getting an interview.
- Your targeted cover letter allows you to show the potential employer **why you are the right person for the job**, by emphasizing, expanding, and complementing several key points related to the employer's needs.
- A professional, well-crafted, interesting, and impressive cover letter **demonstrates your written communication skills** and should **persuade the employer to want to read your resume** and meet with you to further explore your qualifications.

Source

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1.3.1: Cover Letter Types

Types of Cover Letters

There are two types of cover letters that you can prepare:

Targeted

- A targeted cover letter is written **in response to a specific job posting** and is the most commonly used type of letter. You **customize the content of your letter to match the job requirements listed in the advertisement by including keywords from the posting**. Your cover letter should provide concrete examples from your experience of how you have demonstrated the qualifications listed.

Generalized

- A generalized cover letter can be used when you are applying to a company, but you are unaware of the positions that they are hiring for. This type of letter might be **used when attending a career event** where multiple employers are present but the available jobs are unknown. You can also prepare a generalized cover letter for when you find yourself in an unplanned networking situation; your letter will provide your contact with information highlighting your professional accomplishments.

Sources

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1.3.2: Sections

Cover Letter Sections

Your Contact Information

- Your first and last name, current address, phone number, and email address.
- Be sure to **match the format of your resume** to show consistency in your branding.

Date of Submission

- Date that you are applying and submitting your application for the position, written out in long form (ex. March 31, 2021).

Company Name, Department Name, and Address

- Employer's name and title.
- The name of the company and/or department that is listed on the job posting.
- The company's full address.
- If the address is not listed on the posting, search it on the internet. If there are several different locations, reach out to the company directly to find out more information on which location is hiring. If you are still unable to obtain this information, use the Head Office address.

Subject of the Letter (Re:)

- Exact job title and posting number, if one has been provided.
- For example: Re: Part-time Medical Ward Clerk, Day Surgery, Posting #35546.

Greeting

- If the name of the hiring contact and address is not on the posting, put in the extra effort to research this information for yourself.
- Check the company's website, or LinkedIn, or call the company directly to obtain the name of the person in charge of hiring for the position.
- Personalize your greeting to say, "**Dear** *First Name Last Name*." (Public Works and Government Services Canada, Translation Bureau, 2015).
 - For example, if the person's name is **Jackie Chan**, your greeting is "**Dear Jackie Chan**".
 - **Do not use:**
 - "Dear Mr. Chan"
 - "Dear Jackie"
 - "Dear Chan"
 - "Dear Ms. Chan"
 - "Dear Mrs. Chan".
- If you are unable to obtain a specific name, use "Dear Hiring Manager".
- **Do not use a generic greeting such as "To Whom it May Concern".**

Introduction

- The introduction should answer the 4 "W's" Who, Why, What, and Where.
 - **Who:** Introduce yourself to the employer (your program of study) and start with a strong sentence that demonstrates why they should be interested in you.
 - **Why:** Explain briefly why you would like to work for this employer. This paragraph lets the employer know that you have written this letter specifically for them, and demonstrates your knowledge of the company.
 - **Instead of telling the employer what this position can do for you, state what you will bring** and how this makes you a strong fit for the organization. By stating your knowledge of the company and emphasizing your interest, you are setting yourself apart from other candidates. For example, if you are applying for a job because the hours or location are

convenient for you, do not state this in your letter. Instead, research the company's mission, vision, values, etc. to find something that really appeals to you and state, in your letter, how this attracted you to the position.

- **What:** List the job title (If this is a generic cover letter, describe what type of job interests you).
- **Where:** Note whether you are responding to an advertised position, wish to be considered for a prospective opening, or if you were referred to the company by a friend or a colleague. (i.e., how you found out about this position).

Body of the Letter

- Promote yourself; give a summary of your relevant experience and how they meet the employer's needs: e.g. work placements, co-op, applied research, previous employment, years of experience, etc. Use descriptive, positive, action verbs to describe what you can do and keywords from the job posting. Highlight your strongest skills and provide further or more in-depth details about a significant accomplishment or an example that pertains to the job
- **If the job posting lists a skill that you lack, do not draw attention to this skill. Do not apologize for it or even mention it in your letter**

Conclusion

- In closing your cover letter, briefly summarize what you will contribute to the company.
- Mention your enclosed resume, if you haven't done so in the body of your letter.
- Thank the employer for their consideration.
- Provide your contact information and remind them how you can be reached most easily, you can also clarify which times of the day you are most reachable if you have other obligations.
- Clearly and politely ask for an opportunity to meet or discuss your qualifications further.

Signature

- Complete your letter by writing "Sincerely" underneath your last paragraph.
- Skip several spaces and type out your first and last name.
- There are several applications that can be downloaded that allow you to create an importable image of your handwritten signature, which offers a nice professional look to finish off your letter when submitting your applications online.
- At the very bottom, add: **Encl., Enc.** or **Enclosure** (this alerts the reader that there are more pages to read, ie, your resume)

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1.3.3: Tips and Samples

Tips

- **Customize it**

The employers want to see you demonstrate your knowledge of the company, show how you could benefit their team, and provide compelling reasons why you would like to work for them. Emphasize and expand on several key points related to the employer's needs and highlight asset points, such as the ability to work flex hours, willingness to relocate, etc.

- **Do your research**

Read through the “About Us” page on the company's website, their mission statement, and social media sites to get more information and insight into the company before you start writing. Your goal is to make the company believe that they are the one and only place you want to work. This is also good preparation for the common questions that will often be asked, such as: “What do you know about our company/organization and why do you want to work for us?”

- **Personalize it**

Whenever possible, personalize your greeting and address your cover letter to the appropriate individual(s). For some Hiring Managers, this small detail can make the difference between screening you in or out. Also, if you heard about the position from someone you know, or someone you met at an employer event or career fair, make sure to mention their name(s) in your introduction.

- **Be consistent with your format and presentation**

Write your cover letter in a business letter format. Use the same font type and size as your resume. Stick to plain paper and avoid graphics.

- **Follow instructions**

Pay attention to the application instructions, many job postings require you to quote a job number in your cover letter to be considered altogether. The posting may also indicate what preferred file format to submit your document in as well.

Furthermore, there are some trend-setting companies that are challenging the more conventional cover letter formats. Should you be applying to these companies, make sure to closely **read the instructions that are provided on the job posting** and write your cover letter accordingly.

- **Don't duplicate your resume**

Avoid presenting information not covered in the resume, but at the same time do not restate your resume word for word. Rather, summarize your most relevant skills and experiences as they relate to the employer's needs.

- **Be concise**

A three to four-paragraph, one-page cover letter is perfect.

- **Be aware of organization and flow**

A disorganized and poorly written cover letter can be tiresome for an employer to read. Ensure that the content of your letter flows well and that you aren't bouncing back between ideas. Secondly, limit the amount of “I” sentences and run-on sentences; focus on using transition words like, “additionally and furthermore” to make your writing flow more easily.

- **Proofread**

Have a second set of eyes read through your cover letter for mistakes. One grammatical error may mean that your application will not be considered. Furthermore, pay close attention to your details. **If you tend to build off of previously saved cover letters, ensure that you have changed all the pertinent information before sending.** *Submitting a cover letter with the wrong date or employer name on the application may cause an employer to have a negative first impression.*

Cover Letter Sample

Travis Booth
1385 Woodroffe Avenue
Ottawa, ON K2G 1V8
613-727-4723 | bootht@gmail.com

June 28, 2021

Paolo Monroe
David's Tea
339 Richmond Road, Unit #1
Ottawa, ON K2A 0E7

Re: Tea Guide Position, Job ID #1234

Dear Paolo Monroe,

Are you looking to add a motivated and experienced customer service professional with superior communication skills to your team? I believe that my proven enthusiastic attitude, team-oriented approach, and the ability to engage customers will make me an effective Tea Guide at David's Tea. Your company is known for friendly and above-and-beyond customer service, quality, and variety of products. Delivering a high standard of service is important to me and I look forward to working for an organization where passion for customer experience is valued and rewarded.

With over five years of varied retail experience, I demonstrated my dedication to exceeding customer expectations by providing friendly, fast, and efficient service, helping customers find and discover the products that best match their needs and interests. One of the key strengths that I rely on is strong product knowledge. In every new position, I first make sure to gain accurate and detailed information about the products I am selling and continue keeping my knowledge up to date. When working at Millennium One Solutions as a Call Centre Representative, I demonstrated my enthusiasm and the ability to learn company service details in a short period. I was also regarded by my team as a resource person for questions about company services and pricing. With that strong product knowledge, I was successful at upselling additional features by educating customers as to the benefits they will receive.

Other personal qualities that I possess include being a flexible team player who can organize their time effectively to meet assigned goals. In my present position at Loblaws, I hold a record of consistently maintaining the largest section of the store to the store's quality standards, while also properly and attentively directing customer questions. I am also currently studying Business Administration at Algonquin College, where I have gained sound understanding of project planning, professional communication, and marketing basics. These skills will be an asset to your team, where I can contribute to the collection and analysis of data to improve customer engagement, communicate with vendors or larger business clients, and deliver suitable customer solutions.

Thank you for your time and consideration. I would appreciate an opportunity to meet with you in person to discuss how I can make a positive contribution to your team. I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Sincerely,
(add signature)

Travis Booth

Encl.

Source

- Dilgert, E., & Weatherhead, N. (2021). *Career guide for health and wellness office administrative professionals*. Conestoga College.

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2: Ensuring Proper Documentation

Accuracy is Important!

Accurate and thorough data entry is the cornerstone of effective patient care and efficient healthcare operations. From the moment a patient registers at a medical facility, the information collected and documented by administrative professionals becomes part of the official medical record—impacting everything from diagnosis and billing to follow-up care.

In this chapter, you'll explore the essential tasks involved in registering patients, documenting key details, and maintaining up-to-date, compliant records. Whether entering insurance information or updating a patient's contact details, precision and attention to detail are critical skills for every medical office professional.

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2.1: SOAP Notes



What's a SOAP note?

According to the journal *Academic Medicine*, the SOAP format was developed in the 1950s by Lawrence Weed, a professor of medicine and pharmacology at Yale University.

Originally referred to as a problem-oriented medical record (POMR), the SOAP note evolved, and today it's widely used by practitioners across many healthcare disciplines—including mental health professionals—to document and organize findings in an objective way.

Though the specific information and length of these documents varies by discipline, it's important to learn how to write SOAP notes because they all follow the same basic structure. This standardization is easily recognizable by providers in other specialties—making it easy to coordinate care for your clients if needed.

How to write a SOAP note

Learning how to write SOAP notes is generally a straightforward process because it always follows a specific and precise structure. However, it does take some practice.

SOAP notes include four headings that correspond with each letter of the acronym:

- Subjective
- Objective
- Assessment
- Plan

The notes and records you enter under each heading will depend on your clinical specialty, who your client is, and what you're working on during your sessions together.

We've broken down the order of how to write SOAP notes and provided suggestions for what to include in each section as recommended by a review of peer-reviewed articles in StatPearls.

Subjective

This section is for subjective reporting of how your client says they are feeling during the session and what they report about their current symptoms. It can also contain information gathered from family members and reviews of past medical records.

Many mental health practitioners focus on what's known as a "Chief Complaint"(CC) or the presenting problem in this section.

Even if the client reports multiple CCs, it's important to try to identify the most compelling problem so that you can ultimately provide an effective diagnosis.

Some general areas of inquiry as you try to identify the primary CC may include: history of present illness, medical history, review of systems, and current medications.

Here are some questions to ask to help uncover your client's Chief Complaint:

1. Describe your symptoms in detail. When did they start and how long have they been going on?
2. What is the severity of your symptoms and what makes them better or worse?
3. What is your medical and mental health history?
4. What other health-related issues are you experiencing?
5. What medications are you taking?

Make sure any opinions or observations you include in the section are attributed to who said them—whether it's yourself or your client. Because this is a subjective section, you don't want to pass off any of this information as fact.

Objective

The SOAP notes objective section should be made up of physical findings gathered from the session with your client.

Some examples of SOAP charting for this section include:

- Vital signs
- Relevant medical records or information from other specialists
- The client's appearance, behavior, and mood in session

Note: This section should consist of factual information that you observe and not include anything the patient has told you.

Assessment

The assessment section combines all the information gathered from the subjective and objective sections. It's where you describe what you think is going on with the patient.

You can include your impressions and your interpretation of all of the above information, and also draw from any clinical professional knowledge or DSM-5 criteria/therapeutic models to arrive at a diagnosis (or list of possible diagnoses).

Plan

The last section of your SOAP note should outline your plan for next steps to treat the patient, including short- and long-term goals for your patient. Be specific about what you plan to work on in the next session or in general and your expectations for the duration of treatment.

SOAP note example for speech-language pathologists (SLPs)

Speech-language pathologists (SLPs) also need to know how to write SOAP notes, as SLPs use the SOAP format to capture clinical information about client visits, current assessments, and outcomes.

Here's sample SOAP charting copy an SLP might use for a SOAP note:

Subjective

The client reports increased vocal demands since the last meeting due to additional meetings at work. She notes her colleagues commented "Your voice is back!" after her last work presentation, but that she still experiences intermittent vocal fatigue

during social events. She reports she has been incorporating her semi occluded vocal tract straw (SOVT) routine three times a day for five minutes.

Objective

Led the client through SOVT exercises with a straw in water. Client independently achieved optimal voicing in 5/5 opportunities. Introduced conversational training therapy (CTT) where client differentiated between her “husky” voice and her “presenter” voice in 5/5 opportunities. Practiced functional phrases where client achieved “presenter” voice in 8/10 opportunities with moderate visual cues. The client’s vocal effort using CTT was 4/10.

Assessment

The client met goals of optimal voicing to meet vocational demands, as evidenced by an improvement from vocal effort of 7/10 (“somewhat hard”) to 4/10 (“somewhat easy”). She is pressing toward carryover of SOVT strategies to meet social demands.

Plan

Continue the current plan of care. Target optimal voicing in functional environments with CTT techniques. Introduce additional compensatory strategies to manage vocal load across vocational and social settings.

Remember, SOAP notes are meant to document your findings in a way that’s easy to record and refer back to. Consequently, you should use the format that makes the most sense for your practice.

SOAP Notes Activity

Start Activity



- Excelsior Online Writing Lab. (n.d.). [SOAP notes](#). Excelsior University.
- SimplePractice. (n.d.). [How to write SOAP notes](#). (with examples).

[2.1: SOAP Notes](#) is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by Kaitlyn Junk, Western Technical College.

2.2: Minimizing Errors

Minimizing Errors

In healthcare settings, accurate and timely documentation is crucial for providing quality patient care. However, documentation errors can occur for various reasons, leading to potential detrimental impacts on patient safety and healthcare outcomes. As a best practice, healthcare organizations incorporate processes and technology tools to help minimize these errors.

For starters, electronic health records (EHR) include autofill and alert features, standardized documentation templates, and typically establish a peer review process for chart audits. This helps to encourage a culture of quality improvement around documentation. Training staff in proper documentation protocols is another good practice.

Need for Accurate Documentation

Medical records contain an incredible amount of information, such as a patient's medical history, diagnosis, treatments, prescriptions, allergies, test results, and more. They are the main resource used by medical professionals to monitor a patient's health, make diagnoses, and administer the right care.

Mistakes in medical records can result in a variety of issues—incorrect diagnosis and treatment, legal troubles, and higher medical expenses. Furthermore, patients now have direct access to their medical records thanks to patient portals. This transparency also highlights the need for accurate recordkeeping since any errors may impact patient satisfaction, trust, and quality of care.

Typical Mistakes Made in Healthcare Records

- **Typographical errors:** typos and small errors made while typing can change a word or phrase's meaning and cause misunderstanding thereby, leading to significant issues.
- **Transcription errors:** When transcribing notes or dictation manually, there is an increased probability that mistakes may happen, especially if the healthcare provider's handwriting is difficult to read or the audio quality is subpar for the software to interpret.
- **Omissions:** Vital information may unintentionally be omitted, such as a patient's diagnosis history, a treatment administered, or an excerpt from the conversation during doctor/patient interaction due to technical issues or the inability of the software to record the interaction.
- **Inaccurate prescription documents:** Mistakes in the recording of prescription instructions can jeopardize patient safety. It can lead to the wrong treatment, thereby risking the health and trust of the patient.
- **Wrong abbreviations or non-standard usage:** Using unclear abbreviations or nonstandard words could lead to misunderstanding and confusion thereby hindering the care process.
- **Incorrect patient chart:** Incorrect entries in a patient's chart can impede the treatment process. This may particularly happen for patients who share the same name, or any other similar information which can contradict and result in mistakes.
- **Inaccurate demographic information:** Failure to record important details accurately regarding the patient such as their address or phone number can result in a communication breakdown between the healthcare system and the patient and may be a cause of possible privacy infringement
- **Subjective or vague language:** Using language that is subjective or vague might cause ambiguity and possibly misinterpretations for diagnoses and treatment.

The Effects of False Documentation on Medical Records

- **Tagged as malpractice or carelessness:** Inaccurate documentation that does not appropriately reflect the patient's medical needs may result in accusations of malpractice and negligence.
- **Insurance coverage issues:** Patients may not receive essential coverage if their documentation is inaccurate or marked false due to incomplete or wrong details.
- **Inaccurate treatment decisions:** Misdiagnoses, drug interactions, and other negative outcomes may result from treatment choices made based on inaccurate records which can be potentially life-threatening.
- **Inappropriate testing:** A doctor may prescribe unnecessary tests or repeat ones that are already ordered due to incomplete or erroneous paperwork.

- **Hindrance in research and public health initiatives:** The collection of inaccurate population-level data and medical research might be hindered by poorly maintained records.
- **Decreased reimbursements:** When determining the legitimacy of a payment, insurance companies frequently rely on medical records, which if false could lead to the applicant being labeled fraud or in other cases, payment rejections may occur due to inadequate paperwork.

Steps to Prevent Errors and Mistakes

Autofill features: By automatically filling in some fields, highlighting information that is missing, and guarding against errors like misreading handwriting, EHR systems help to reduce errors. Staff members can adhere to consistent formatting thanks to standardized templates. Peer reviews point out any issues with the documentation. Encouraging a company culture that prioritizes quality improvement will support ongoing initiatives to improve documentation through process enhancements, learning opportunities, and feedback.

Standardize documentation processes: Standardizing documentation processes across healthcare settings can help reduce errors by ensuring consistency and clarity in documenting patient information along with providing uniformity. This can include using standardized forms, templates, and EHR systems to capture and store patient data accurately.

Provide training and education: Healthcare professionals should receive comprehensive training and education on documentation best practices, including proper charting techniques, use of medical terminology, and understanding of documentation requirements and regulations. Providing routine education and training opportunities can help ensure that staff members are equipped with the necessary skills to document accurately.

- Guarantees that employees understand what data must be recorded.
- Highlights necessary procedures for documentation.
- Provides guidance on how to avoid typical mistakes like illegible or missing data.
- Encourages complete, accurate charting for optimal best practices.

Implement quality assurance measures: Establishing quality assurance measures, such as regular chart audits and reviews, can help identify documentation errors and areas for improvement. By conducting regular assessments of documentation practices, healthcare organizations can proactively address issues and prevent errors from recurring.

Use of technology: Implementing technology, such as electronic health records (EHRs), clinical decision support systems, and [AI transcription tools](#) can help streamline documentation processes and reduce the risk of errors. However, healthcare professionals need to use technology wisely and be mindful of potential pitfalls, such as copy-and-paste errors and reliance on auto-populated fields.

Encourage clear and concise communication: Effective communication among healthcare team members is essential for accurate documentation. Encouraging clear and concise communication through standardized handoff processes and interdisciplinary collaboration can help ensure that vital patient information is accurately documented and shared among providers.

Foster a culture of accountability: Creating a culture of accountability within healthcare organizations can help promote responsible documentation practices. This includes holding staff members accountable for their documentation accuracy and providing feedback and support to address any identified issues.

Address documentation fatigue: Healthcare professionals often must manage a heavy load of documentation which can contribute to fatigue and an increased risk of errors. Addressing documentation fatigue through workload management strategies, such as prioritizing essential documentation tasks and implementing time-saving scribe tools, can help mitigate the risk of errors.

Conduct training regularly on legal and ethical considerations: Healthcare professionals should receive regular training on legal and ethical considerations related to documentation, including patient privacy laws, informed consent requirements, and documentation of adverse events. This ongoing education can help ensure that documentation practices align with regulatory standards and ethical guidelines.

Establish clear documentation policies and procedures: Clear and comprehensive documentation policies and procedures should be established within healthcare organizations to guide proper documentation practices. These policies should address requirements

for documenting patient assessments, interventions, and outcomes, as well as guidelines for correcting errors and documenting late entries.

Closing Thoughts

By implementing these strategies to minimize errors in healthcare documentation, healthcare professionals can provide accurate, reliable, and timely documentation in healthcare settings. Ultimately, improving documentation practices can contribute to enhanced patient safety, better care coordination, and improved healthcare outcomes. All parties involved in the implementation of these strategies—including administrators and healthcare providers—must work together to succeed in their execution. The rewards are well worth the work, as evidenced by improved patient safety, higher-quality care, and heightened confidence in the healthcare system.

Source

- Innovaccer. (2024, May 10). [Strategies for minimizing errors in healthcare documentation](#).

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2.3: Avoiding Four Common Errors

Avoid These Four Common Errors

The electronic health record (EHR) is designed to improve patient care and streamline physician workflow. With the widespread adoption of digitized patient records, medical transcription companies enter physician narrations directly into the EHR instead of into word processing systems. Medical transcription services ease physician burnout, improve document quality, and increase patient satisfaction. However, many studies suggest that EHR users are highly prone to making errors which can endanger the reliability of information, and thereby patient care, safety and the provider's bottomline.

- **Medication Errors:** More than 30 percent of all EHR-related malpractice claims are associated with medication errors, according to a study in the Journal of Patient Safety in 2019. On analyzing 248 malpractice claims involving EHR technology, the researchers found that 31 percent of these claims involved medication errors. Another study reported that two-thirds of prescription errors (65.7%) occurred during prescribing or transcribing (info.nhanow.com). Causes include: entering wrong information, entering information in the wrong place, and overlooking EHR flags/warnings for interactions or contraindications. Serious harmful results of a medication error may include death, life threatening events, hospitalization, disability, etc.

Training users on EHR processes can minimize prescription errors. Outsourcing medical transcription to an experienced service provider can prevent potentially harmful medication errors.

- **Patient Identification Errors:** Patient ID errors are another common problems associated with EHRs. Correct patient identification is fundamental to safe care delivery. However, an ECRI Institute study found that the risk of wrong-patient errors is a chronic problem with the large numbers of patient encounters occurring daily in healthcare settings. According to the study, patient identification errors in the EHR were quite common, leading to injury, wrong treatment, and even death. A 2018 Pew Charitable Trusts report revealed that one out of every five patients may not be completely matched to their medical records. Charting to the wrong patient occur when the admission, discharge, transfer (ADT) system fails to put a patient in a bed in a timely manner, according to a Healthcare IT News article.

While EHRs are a major step towards going paperless, digitization of patient records has led to duplicate and disparate medical records. Patient information in EHRs is also inconsistent as systems have different ways of capturing patient demographic information. Leveraging an efficient enterprise master patient index (EMPI) industry best practice essential to prevent duplicates and inaccurate patient information, according to a Health IT Outcomes report.

- **Inaccurate Medical History:** Patients who read their own records online often find mistakes in their medical history, some of which are serious. An January 2021 article in physiciansweekly.com references a study that found that of 22,889 surveyed patients who read their own records, 4830 (25%) found mistakes. While 10% were classified as very serious, 42.3% were reported as serious, and 32.4% as somewhat serious. When patients were asked to provide free text descriptions of mistakes, it was found that the most common type of error involved a current or previous diagnosis.

Simple miskeying could be the reason for such errors. On the other hand, miscommunication or wrong information from the patient could also lead to errors in medical history and bad data in the EHR (healthcareitnews.com). Allowing patients to review their notes routinely could improve EHR accuracy and also provide an opportunity for organizational learning. If patients find errors in their records, they should make sure they are corrected.

- **Flaws in EHR System Design:** Apart from user-related problems, studies have reported that EHR system design flaws can lead to a glitch and cause inaccurate recording of patient information, such as allergies or medications. Software bugs, disorganized data, system interface problems, and missing/corrupted data can affect decision making, and lead to delays, errors, unnecessary testing, and system downtime. Fortunately, EHR companies are working to ease the tech burden on healthcare providers and improving system design to enhance the clinical decision making process.

With the increasing scope and complexity of tasks that clinicians can perform using EHRs, effective end-user training is critical for success. Benefits of effective training programs include greater accuracy in charting and coding, improved productivity and efficiency that benefits both providers and their patients. Outsourcing medical transcription can optimize the EHR documentation process to support delivery of superior quality care and enhanced ROI for healthcare organizations.

Source

- Clements, J. (2021, May 27). [Four common EHR errors and how to avoid them](#). Medical Transcription Service Company.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Health Insurance

[3.1: Prior Authorizations](#)

[3.2: Insurance Claims](#)

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3.1: Prior Authorizations

Prior Authorizations

Under medical and prescription drug plans, some treatments and medications may need approval from your health insurance carrier **before** you receive care.

Prior authorization is usually required if you need a complex treatment or prescription. Coverage will not happen without it. That's why beginning the prior authorization process early is important.

Ask your health care provider if a prescription or medical treatment is going to require prior authorization so they can start the process immediately.

This is not the same as if you need additional treatments or prescriptions **after** your initial visit. In that instance, you may need to get a medical necessity review, or "authorization."

NOTE: There are many terms that mean the same as "**prior authorization**," including:

- Preauthorization
- Preapproval
- Precertification

They all mean the same thing.

Location Authorizations

Prior authorization may be needed before getting outpatient services in a hospital or hospital-affiliated facility. This "place of service" authorization may help guide providers and customers to a more cost-efficient location, while ensuring quality of care, when use of an outpatient hospital is not medically necessary.

What types of medical treatments and medications may need prior authorization?

- Medications that may be unsafe when combined with other medications
- Medical treatments that have lower-cost, but equally effective, alternatives available
- Medical treatments and medications that should only be used for certain health conditions
- Medical treatments and medications that are often misused or abused
- Drugs often used for cosmetic purposes

No Surprises Act

The No Surprises Act was enacted in 2020 and goes into effect on January 1, 2022. It provides federal consumer protections against unanticipated out-of-network bills called "surprise bills."

Surprise bills arise in emergencies when patients typically have little or no say in where they receive care. They also arise in non-emergencies when patients at in-network hospitals or facilities receive care from providers (such as anesthesiologists) who are not in-network and whom the patient did not choose.

The law requires surprise bills must be covered without prior authorization and in-network cost sharing must apply.¹

How do I get a prior authorization?

If your health care provider is in-network, they will start the prior authorization process.

If you don't use a health care provider in your plan's network, then you are responsible for obtaining the prior authorization. If you don't obtain it, the treatment or medication might not be covered, or you may need to pay more out of pocket.

Review your plan documents or call the number on your health plan ID card for more information about the treatments, services, and supplies that require prior authorization under your specific plan.

How does the prior authorization process work?

Typically, within 5-10 business days of receiving the prior authorization request, your insurance company will either:

- Approve your request
- Deny your request
- Ask for more information
- Recommend you try an alternative that's less costly, but equally effective, before your original request is approved

These responses are based on input from clinical pharmacists and medical doctors who review the requests at the health insurance company.

If you're unhappy with your prior authorization response, you or your health care provider can ask for a review of the decision.

Is prior authorization required in emergency situations?

No, prior authorization is not required if you have an emergency and need medication. However, coverage for emergency medical costs are subject to the terms of your health plan.

Why does my health insurance company need a prior authorization?

The prior authorization process gives your health insurance company a chance to review how necessary a medical treatment or medication may be in treating your condition.

For example, some brand-name medications are very costly. During their review, your health insurance company may decide a generic or another lower-cost alternative may work just as well in treating your medical condition.

How does prior authorization help me?

The prior authorization process can help you:

- Reduce the cost of expensive treatments and prescriptions by first requiring you to try a lower-cost alternative
- Avoid potentially dangerous medication combinations
- Avoid prescribed treatments and medications you may not need or those that could be addictive

Review your plan documents or call the number on your plan ID card for more information about the treatments, services, and supplies that require prior authorization under your specific plan.

Source

- This content was originally written by me (Kaitlyn Junk). ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2024) was used to enhance clarity and professionalism through suggested edits. Final content was reviewed and approved by me.

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3.2: Insurance Claims



The Health Insurance Claims Process

The health insurance claim process ensures that healthcare providers receive payment for services rendered and that patients obtain the benefits covered by their insurance plans. This process begins when a patient receives medical care, and the provider documents the visit, including diagnoses and procedures performed. Medical coders then assign standardized codes (ICD-10, CPT, and HCPCS) to ensure accurate billing. Once coded, the claim is prepared and submitted—either electronically or manually—to the patient’s insurance company for review.

The insurance company then processes the claim by verifying patient eligibility, reviewing coverage details, and ensuring that any required prior authorization was obtained. If the claim is approved, the insurer pays its portion, and any remaining balance, such as co-pays or deductibles, becomes the patient’s responsibility. If the claim is denied due to missing information, incorrect coding, or lack of prior authorization, it must be corrected and resubmitted, which can lead to delays in payment and patient care.

Accuracy in the claim process is critical. Even minor spelling or grammatical errors in patient names, policy numbers, or service descriptions can cause mismatches in the system, leading to claim rejections. Proper documentation and coding are essential to avoid compliance issues, denials, and potential fraud allegations. Additionally, some services require prior authorization, meaning the provider must obtain approval from the insurance company before proceeding with treatment. This step ensures medical necessity, controls healthcare costs, and confirms adherence to insurance guidelines. If prior authorization is not secured when required, the claim may be denied, leaving the patient financially responsible or delaying necessary care.

A well-managed claim process supports the financial stability of healthcare facilities while ensuring that patients receive timely and appropriate medical treatment. By prioritizing accuracy, attention to detail, and adherence to insurance policies, healthcare professionals can help minimize errors, reduce claim denials, and streamline the reimbursement process.

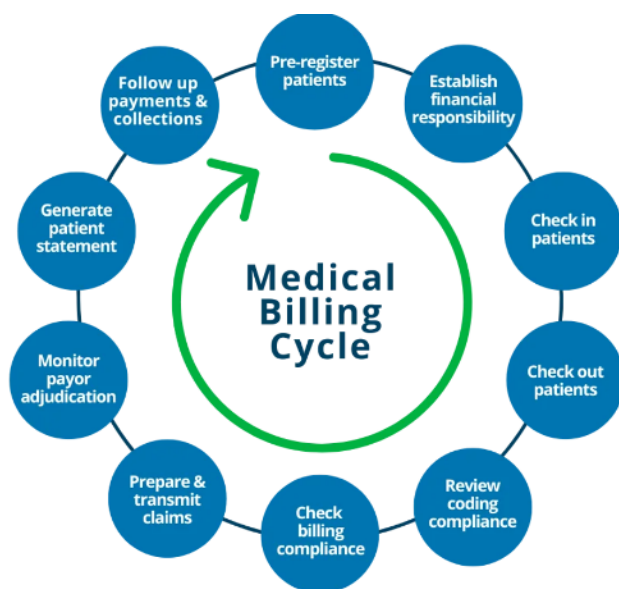
How does the insurance claims process fit into the cycle?

Fig. 3.2 The Medical Billing Cycle: Pre-Register patients, Establish financial responsibility, Check in patients, Check out patients, Review coding compliance, Check billing compliance, Prepare and transmit claims, Monitor payor adjudication, Generate patient statement, Follow up payments & Collections.

Image Source: [Denial Management in Medical Billing: The Ultimate Guide](#). JTS Health Partners. September 2022.

Sources

- State of Maryland. 2020. [Understanding the Health Insurance Claim Process](#).
- Some content was originally written by me (Kaitlyn Junk). ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2024) was used to enhance clarity and professionalism through suggested edits. Final content was reviewed and approved by me.
- [Denial Management in Medical Billing: The Ultimate Guide](#). JTS Health Partners. September 2022.



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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: HIPAA Compliant Communications

[4.1: What is HIPAA?](#)

[4.2: Effective and Compliant Communication](#)

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4.1: What is HIPAA?

The Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA)

The Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA), passed in 1996, is a federal law that protects sensitive patient information. Its primary goal is to ensure that individuals' health information is properly safeguarded while still allowing the flow of health data needed to provide high-quality care. HIPAA sets the standard for how healthcare providers, insurance companies, and healthcare clearinghouses (known as "covered entities") handle protected health information (PHI). This includes everything from medical histories and diagnoses to billing information and insurance records.

HIPAA has two main components that affect everyday healthcare work: the **Privacy Rule** and the **Security Rule**. The Privacy Rule focuses on how PHI can be used and disclosed, setting limits on when and with whom patient information can be shared. The Security Rule outlines the safeguards that must be in place to protect electronic health records (EHRs) from unauthorized access, whether intentional or accidental. These safeguards include physical security (like locking up files), technical protections (such as password protection), and administrative policies (like staff training and access restrictions).

For those working in administrative and secretarial roles, HIPAA compliance is part of everyday responsibility. Whether you're speaking with patients, answering phones, handling documents, or working in scheduling software, you're likely accessing or handling PHI. It's your job to make sure that information is kept private and only shared with authorized individuals. That means not discussing patient details in public areas, securing printed materials, logging out of computers when stepping away, and verifying a patient's identity before sharing information over the phone.

HIPAA is important not just because it's the law—but because it builds trust. Patients are more likely to be honest and open about their health when they know their information is safe. Following HIPAA guidelines protects the patient, the provider, and you as the employee. Violations can lead to serious legal consequences, but even more importantly, they can damage a patient's experience and confidence in the care they receive. Understanding HIPAA is a core part of being a trusted and professional member of any healthcare team.

Source

- U.S. Department of Health and Human Services. (n.d.). [HIPAA for professionals](https://www.hhs.gov/hipaa). HHS.gov.

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4.2: Effective and Compliant Communication

Effective and Compliant Communication

In healthcare, communication isn't just a task—it's a skill that can significantly influence the success of an organization and the well-being of its patients. Every phone call answered, message relayed, or instruction given plays a role in the patient's experience and overall quality of care. As a medical administrative professional, you are often the first point of contact for patients. The way you communicate—verbally and nonverbally—can set the tone for the entire visit and build trust between the patient and the healthcare team.

One of the most critical aspects of professional communication in healthcare is respecting patient privacy. You've likely already learned about HIPAA and the legal requirements that come with handling protected health information (PHI). But applying those expectations to real-life scenarios is where your professionalism truly shines. Consider this: a patient calls the office to ask about a lab result, and someone else answers on their behalf. Do you have documented consent to speak to that person? Are you in a private location where no one else can overhear? These are the types of quick decisions you'll make every day—decisions that reflect your awareness of privacy standards and your ability to act with integrity.

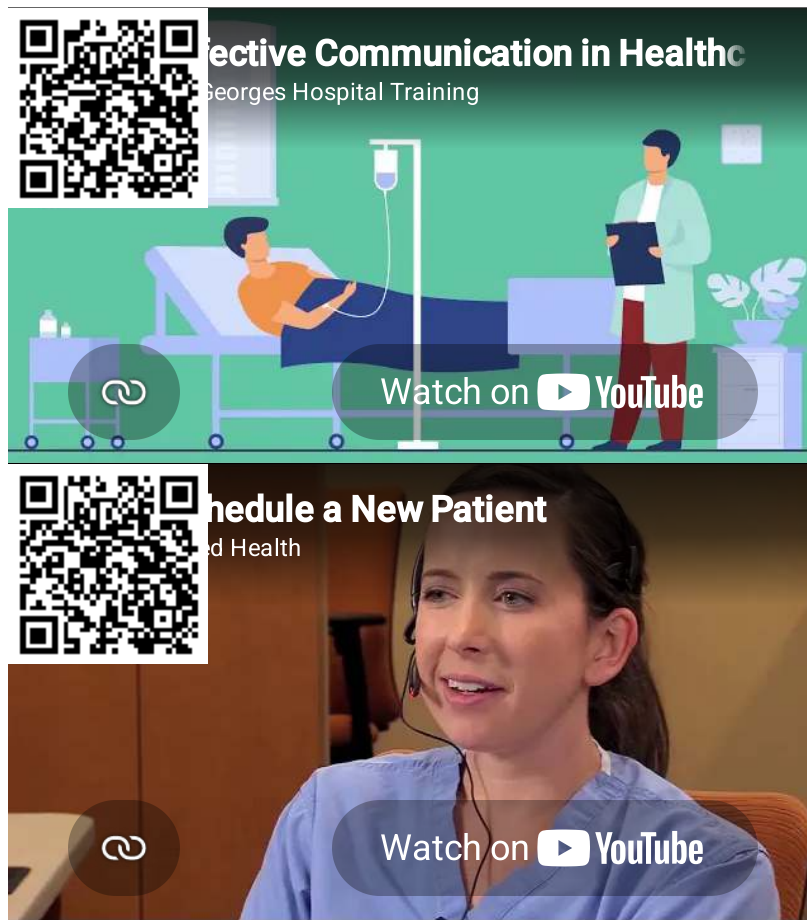
Professional, HIPAA-compliant communication also requires thoughtfulness in how you present information. For instance, when leaving voicemails, it's best practice to avoid sharing specific medical details unless the patient has given prior permission. Instead, you might say, "This is the clinic calling to follow up—please return our call at your earliest convenience." In the office, use discretion when speaking in public areas or displaying information on screens. A simple slip—like mentioning a diagnosis at the front desk or leaving a chart open where others can see—can unintentionally compromise patient confidentiality.

But privacy is only one part of effective communication. Equally important is your ability to express yourself clearly, confidently, and compassionately. In healthcare settings, patients may be feeling unwell, confused, or anxious. Your tone, pacing, and body language all contribute to how your message is received. For example, if a patient is upset about a billing issue, how you listen and respond matters just as much as the solution you offer. Using a calm voice, validating their concerns, and offering to investigate or follow up shows empathy and professionalism—even if you're not the one who caused the issue.

Clarity is also key. Using everyday language instead of technical terms helps patients understand instructions and make informed decisions about their care. It's a good habit to ask if the patient has any questions or to invite them to repeat back what they understood. This not only helps catch misunderstandings but also shows that you care about their comfort and clarity.

Internal communication with colleagues is just as critical. Accurate documentation, timely messages, and clear notes in the electronic health record (EHR) help the entire team stay informed and deliver consistent care. When relaying information from a provider or patient, double-check that you've captured the details accurately and documented them in the appropriate place. Miscommunication among staff can lead to scheduling errors, delays in care, or even safety risks. Strong internal communication habits make you a dependable part of the team.

Ultimately, effective and compliant communication in healthcare is about more than checking boxes—it's about supporting a system where patients feel respected, staff stay coordinated, and everyone works together toward the shared goal of better health outcomes. As a medical administrative professional, you have the opportunity to be a calm, competent voice patients can trust and a key connection between patients and providers. When you communicate with care, professionalism, and purpose, you help create a safer, more welcoming healthcare environment for everyone.



Sources

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